

Event Information:

EventID :
78
Event Time :
Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM
Rule :
SOC139 - Meterpreter or Empire Activity
Level :
Security Analyst
Source Address :
172.16.17.55
Source Hostname :
Alex - HP
File Name :
cobaltstrike_shellcode.exe
File Hash :
24d99ba5654cdf31141c66fd9417b7e0
File Size :
219.00 Kb
Device Action :
Allowed

Analysis Steps:

Logs were searched with source IP 172[.]16.17.55 (Alex - HP) 172[.]16.17.16 in the relevant time-frame yielding 2 events. It shows what appears to be C2 activity stemming from the malicious Cobaltstrike executable. However, available logs do not appear to indicate how the file was delivered to the device.

The screenshot shows a security log viewer interface. At the top, a search bar contains the text "Source Address contains '172.16.17.55'". Below the search bar, it indicates "2 events (before Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM UTC)". The main content area displays a table of event details. The table has two columns: "Field" and "Value". The fields listed are type, source_address, source_port, destination_address, destination_port, and time. The values are Firewall, 172.16.17.55, 14411, 120.79.181.138, 443, and Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM respectively. Below the table, there is a section labeled "Raw Log" which contains a single line of log data: "[Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM] source_address=172.16.17.55 source_port=14411 destination_address=120.79.181.138 destination_port=443 raw_log: ('; ')"

Field	Value
type	Firewall
source_address	172.16.17.55
source_port	14411
destination_address	120.79.181.138
destination_port	443
time	Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM

Raw Log

[Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM] source_address=172.16.17.55 source_port=14411 destination_address=120.79.181.138 destination_port=443 raw_log: ('; ')

On VirusTotal 63/69 Vendors list the file as malicious as of 19 days ago.

63
/69
Community
Score

63/69 security vendors flagged this file as malicious

ReanalyzeSimilarMore

b9331c27be4295c15d7f91faf20d1ccac321204b7ebc2fed83d6a0197cf9
cobaltstrike_shellcode.bin

Size
219.00 KB

Last Analysis Date
19 days ago

EXE

peexechecks-user-inputruntime-modulesdetect-debug-environmentchecks-network-adaptersideirect-cpu-clock-accessspreadersleeps

DETECTIONDETAILSRELATIONSBEHAVIORCOMMUNITY35+

Join our Community and enjoy additional community insights and crowd-sourced detections, plus an API key to automate checks.

Popular threat labeltrojan.cobaltstrike.cobalt

Threat categoriestrojanvirus

Family labelscobaltstrikecobaltromea

Security vendors' analysis

Do you want to automate checks?

Acronis (Static ML)	Suspicious	AhnLab-V3	Trojan.Win.CobaltStrike.B470119
Alibaba	Backdoor.Win32/Beacon.5a279581	Allicloud	Backdoor.Win/CobaltStrike.Artifact.3A4
ALYac	Trojan.CobaltStrike.FM	Antiy-AVL	Trojan(Spy)/Win32.Beacon
Avast	Trojan.CobaltStrike.FM	Arctic Wolf	Unsafe
Avira	Win32/Malware.gen (Hack)	AVG	Win32/Malware.gen (Hack)
Avgas (no cloud)	TR/CryptXPACK.Gen	BitDefender	Trojan.CobaltStrike.FM

VirusTotal also show that the malicious file makes contact with the same C2 IP seen in our logs.

HTTP Requests

+ GET https://120.79.181.138:443/pixel 200

GET http://120.79.181.138:443/pixel

GET https://120.79.181.138/pixel

CONNECT work

AnyRun further evidences the files malicious nature by listing it as conducting malicious activity and again the same C2 IP address can be seen.

ANY.RUN

Malicious activity

cobaltstrike_shellcode.exe

Win10 64bit

MD5: 24D99BA5654CDF31141C6AFD941787E0

Start: 08-03-2026, 01:59

Total time: 67 s

Indicators: Tracker: Cobalt Strike

ResultsNEWGet sampleRestart

Processes 2Browser Data 0NEWActions 0beta

Filter by PID or nameOnly Important

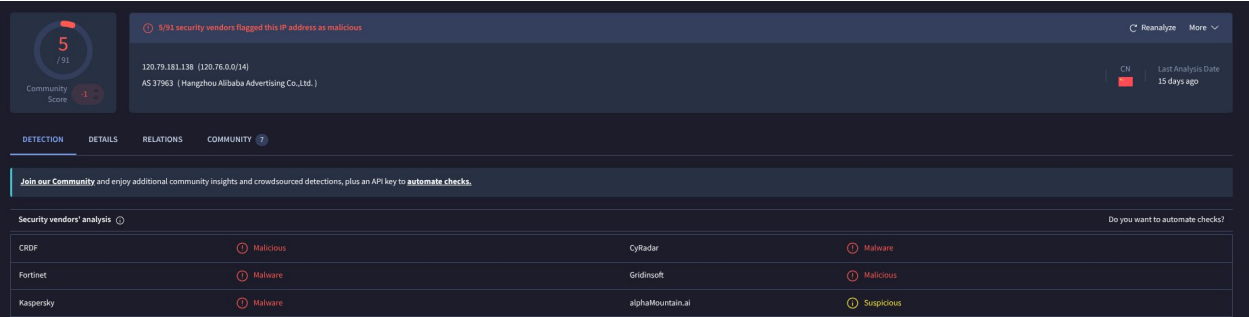
8828	cobaltstrike_shellcode.exe	PE	CFO	DMP	cobaltstrike	383	589	55
7640	COM siui.exe -Embedding					707	419	43

HTTP Requests22Connections21DNS Requests16Network Threats1

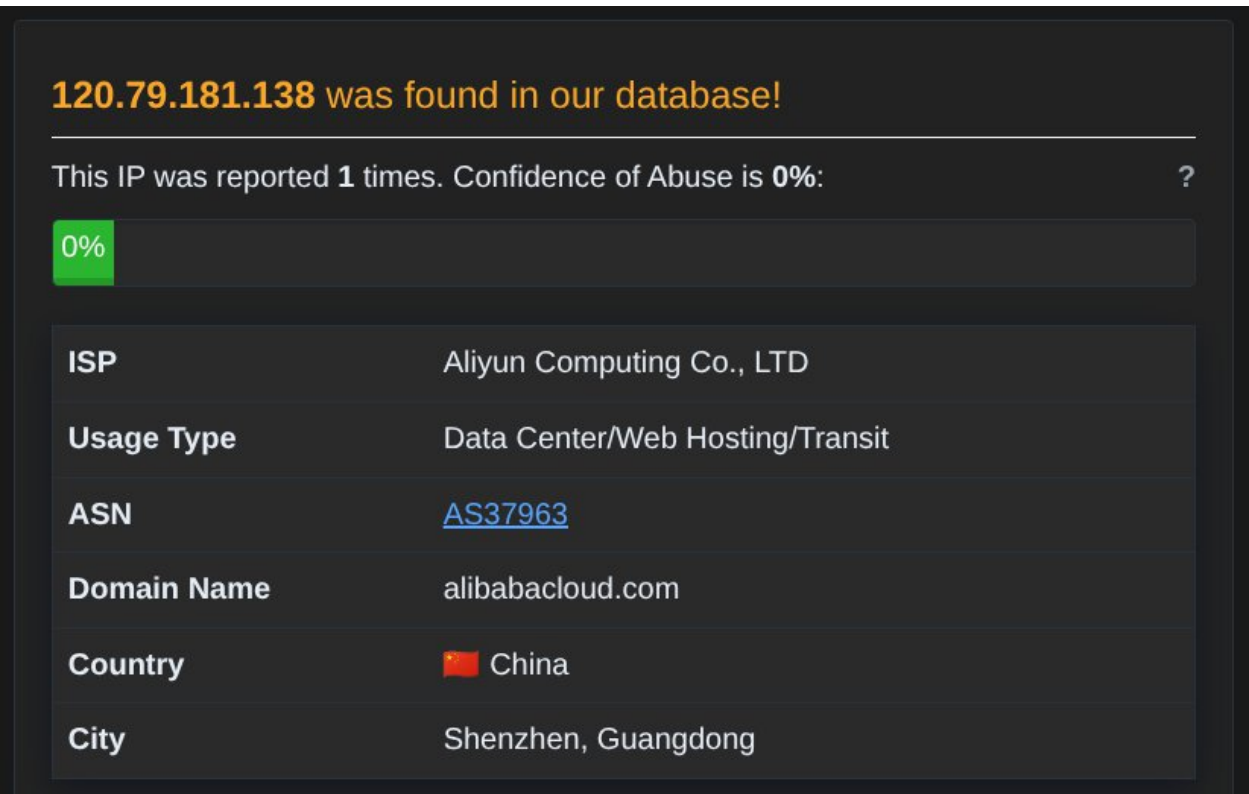
Timeshift	Protocol	Rep	PID	Process name	CN	IP	Port	
BEFORE	TCP	0/68	8828	MalwareCoreWorker.exe		20.73.194.208	443	
1337 ms	TCP	?	8828	cobaltstrike_shellcode...		120.79.181.138	443	ALIBABA-CN-NE...
1348 ms	UDP	4	System			192.168.100.255	138	Not routed
7483 ms	TCP	6320	svchost.exe		40.127.240.158	443	settings.wi...	MICROSOFT.CO...
7519 ms	TCP	6320	svchost.exe		23.216.77.6	80	crf.microso...	AKAMAI-ASN1
7531 ms	TCP	6320	svchost.exe		88.221.169.152	80	www.micro...	AKAMAI-AS
9484 ms	TCP	6320	svchost.exe		40.127.240.158	443	settings.wi...	MICROSOFT.CO...

ALIBABA-CN-NET Hangzhou Alibaba Advertising Co.,Ltd.

The offending IP is not in our CTI database and is external to the organisation. No emails have been received indicating penetration testing involving the IP for the relevant time period. VirusTotal indicates it is a Chinese address associated with (120[.]76.0.0/14) AS 37963 (Hangzhou Alibaba Advertising Co.,Ltd.). 5/91 security vendors flagged this IP address as malicious.



On AbuseIPDB this IP was reported 1 time with a 0% confidence of abuse.



Based on following Playbook procedure and the analysis of available information, this alert is determined to be a successful True Positive.

Report:

Incident Summary

Analysis confirms a True Positive malware execution on the host Alex - HP. A malicious executable identified as a Cobalt Strike payload was allowed to run by endpoint defences. Subsequent firewall logs confirm the compromised host successfully established C2 communications with an external, malicious IP address.

Incident Details

- **Alert Name:** SOC139 - Meterpreter or Empire Activity
- **Event Time:** Mar, 15, 2021, 02:15 PM
- **Target Host:** Alex - HP (172[.]16.17.55)
- **File Name:** cobaltstrike_shellcode.exe
- **File Hash (MD5):** 24d99ba5654cdf31141c66fd9417b7e0

Analysis and Evidence

- **Endpoint Telemetry:** The device reported a Device Action of Allowed, confirming the payload executed successfully.
- **Network Logs:** Firewall logs show two events originating from the target host, successfully connecting to the external IP 120[.]79.181.138 over port 443.
- **Malware Analysis:** VirusTotal (63/69 vendors) and AnyRun both confirm the file is a malicious Cobalt Strike beacon. Both platforms recorded the malware reaching out to the exact same C2 IP address (120[.]79.181.138) observed in our network logs.

Threat Intelligence

- **External Entity:** The C2 IP (120[.]79.181.138) is external to the organisation and maps to Alibaba Cloud infrastructure in China.
- **Internal Correlation:** There is no record of this IP in our CTI database, and internal communications confirm no authorised penetration testing is currently scheduled.

Actions Taken

- Contained the host (Alex - HP) from the network to prevent further lateral movement or data exfiltration.
- Declared True Positive and escalated.

Let's Defend Result

SOC139 - Meterpreter or Empire Activity

True Positive (+5 Point)

Check If Someone Requested the C2 (+5 Point)

Analyze Malware (+5 Point)

Check if the malware is quarantined/cleaned (+5 Point)